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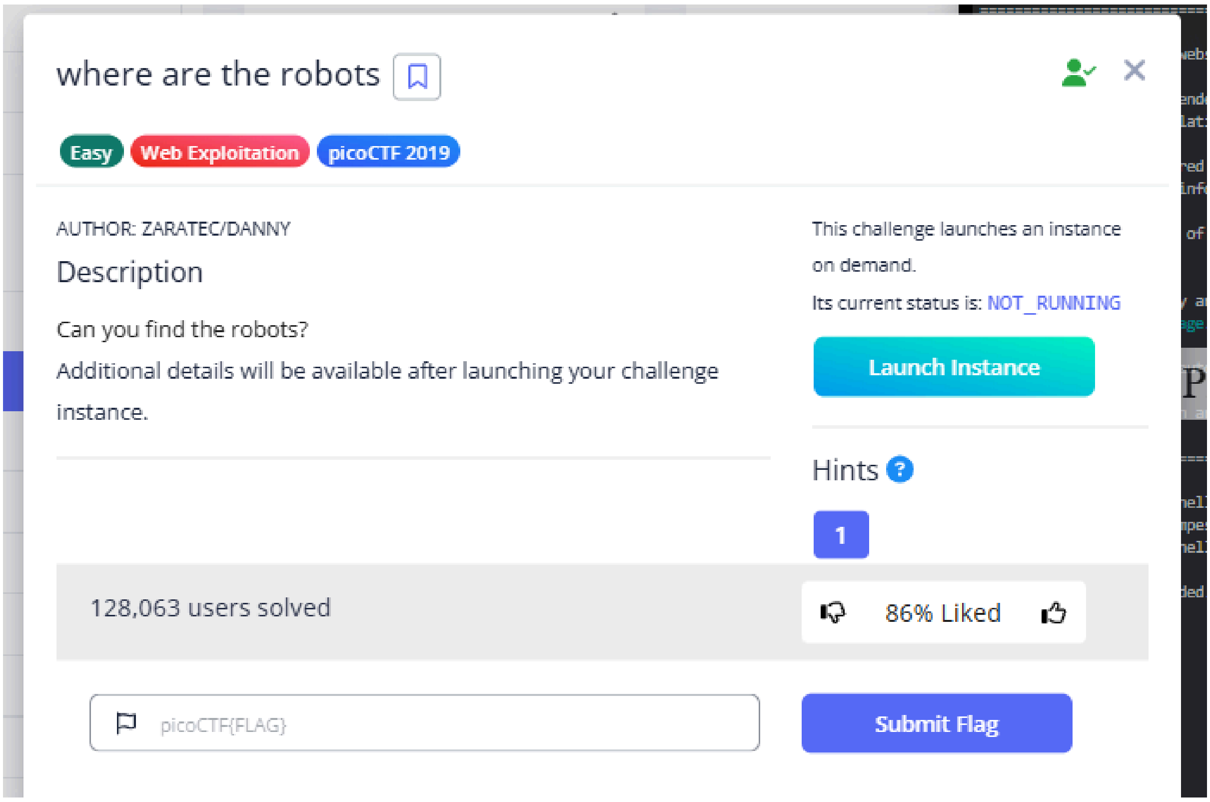
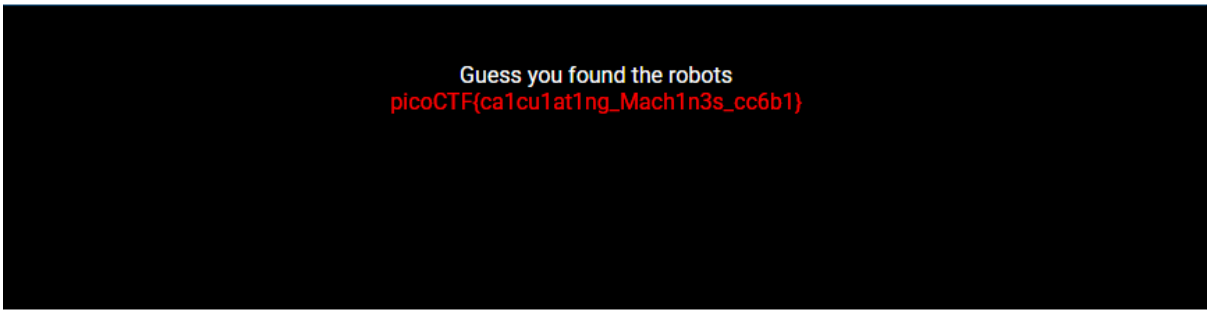
[picoCTF - picoGym Challenges]





Write- Up: WHERE ARE THE ROBOTS

In this challenge, I was tasked with uncovering hidden content on a web server. The prompt asked, *"Can you find the robots?"* a clear hint toward the presence of a `robots.txt` file. This file is commonly used by websites to instruct search engines about which directories should not be indexed, but in Capture the Flag (CTF) contexts, it often reveals sensitive paths that lead to flags.

Step 1: Accessing the Challenge

I began by visiting the provided URL. The landing page displayed a simple message: *"Welcome. Where are the robots?"* This reinforced the idea that the solution lay in examining the site's `robots.txt`.

Step 2: Checking `robots.txt`

Appending `/robots.txt` to the base URL, I discovered the following directive:

Code
User-agent: *
Disallow: /cc6b1.html

This line indicated that all web crawlers were disallowed from accessing the page `/cc6b1.html`. In a real-world scenario, such a directive might be used to hide sensitive or administrative pages. In the context of picoCTF, it was the breadcrumb leading me to the flag.

Step 3: Navigating to the Hidden Path

I followed the disallowed path by visiting:

http://fickle-tempest.picoctf.net:50437/cc6b1.html

This page revealed a message: *"Guess you found the robots"* — and beneath it, the flag itself.

Step 4: Retrieving the Flag

The flag was displayed in the standard picoCTF format:

picoCTF{ca1cu1at1ng_Mach1n3s_cc6b1}

This exercise highlighted the importance of exploring seemingly mundane files like `robots.txt`. While its intended purpose is to guide search engine crawlers, it can inadvertently expose sensitive directories. In penetration testing and web exploitation, checking `robots.txt` is a fundamental reconnaissance step. The challenge reinforced the lesson that security through obscurity is not reliable if something is worth hiding, it should be properly secured, not merely disallowed from indexing.